GTM engineer flood and repositioning

Restore the bigram, sell the system

The October 12 edit was right about the problem and wrong about the mechanism. The "GTM Engineer" flood is real on the supply side (a self-selected 2026 survey puts the median title-holder at age 25, 53% self-taught, 28% ex-SDR, 30% at agencies; an estimated 45% of title-holders are agencies or consultants) but in-house demand has not collapsed: trackers show roughly 250 distinct GTM-engineer roles posted every 30 days in October 2026, 78% of them titled with the bare noun and no level, and senior IC bands sit at $150K–$250K (GTME Pulse survey; Growth Unhinged; getaob tracker). Recruiter inbound collapsed because the edit removed the literal string "GTM Engineer" from all three fields LinkedIn Recruiter matches independently (current-position title, headline, Open to Work titles) and replaced it with "GTM Engineering", which no LinkedIn documentation says is stemmed to the noun; a one-person firm titled "Director" and "Founder & Principal" is also likely re-bucketed by Recruiter's inferred-seniority model into Director/Owner, which recruiters filling Senior and Lead IC seats exclude (Leonar; Job Search Unlocked). The strategic instinct was correct: the bare title is now indistinguishable from a bootcamp graduate without proof, buyers of consulting do not find practitioners by title search at all, and the senior money in adjacent roles sits under "GTM Systems", "Director of Revenue Operations" and "Director, GTM Engineering" strings, not under a bare "GTM Engineer" (Garrett Wolfe; GTMbud; WTTJ LaunchDarkly). The fix is a hybrid: put "Principal GTM Engineer" back in the position title and at the front of the headline, carry seniority and the production-AI proof in the words after it, list the bare noun plus step-up titles in Open to Work, and run client acquisition through a named method, anonymized before/after receipts, and 20–30 targeted accounts at the expert price band ($250–350/hr or $20–28K/month) rather than through the headline, which buyers never read first (GTME; Databar). Measure both goals separately over six weeks, hold the strings for the full window, and use the posting tracker as the market control.

The flood is entry-tier supply, not a demand collapse

Every "3,000+ open GTM Engineer roles" headline traces to one vendor chain (GTME Pulse to eMarketer to Cleanlist, LinkedOtter, Apollo and Stacker) using loose keyword matching, and the two cleanest independent counts are far smaller. Revnu de-duplicated 209 raw LinkedIn postings to 131 (one employer's city duplicates were 38% of the raw results) and estimated 300–400 true employers hiring at any time; GTMhub sampled 1,580 GTM job posts from 1,318 companies on October 15 and 22, 2026 and found only **30 (1.9%) carried the GTM engineer title**, while 62% of hits on a "GTM engineer" search were actually sales, solutions or presales engineer roles (Revnu; GTM Engineer Pulse #47). Kyle Poyar's Sumble analysis a year earlier found 45 title-exact posts a

month and concluded there were likely “more posts about the role than companies hiring for it” (Growth Unhinged). The getaob/Blitz index, which excludes agencies, is the most useful operational number: **251 distinct roles in the 30 days to October 26, 2026, 104 of them US-located, 62 new in the last week**, flat to slightly up against the 90-day average (getaob). Demand is thin but stable; it is not contracting.

Supply is where the flood lives. The State of GTME 2026 survey (n=228, self-selected, anyone who held the title in the past 12 months) reports a **median age of 25, 53% self-taught, entry paths of SDR/BDR 28%, RevOps 22%, Sales Ops 15%, software engineering 8%, and 30% working at agencies serving 3–8 clients at once** (GTME Pulse survey). Clay’s partner directory listed 120+ agencies by September 2025 and roughly 185 by 2026, which Jeff Ignacio computed as about three agencies per new full-time opening (RevOps Impact; Salesforge). Course sellers self-report 300+ and 900+ alumni, an offshore “GTM Engineering Academy Manila” issues certificates, and a jobs marketplace publishes a nine-stage “become a GTM engineer” roadmap, which is what an entry-level career track looks like when it is being manufactured (SyncGTM; landedjobs). The 1–2 daily connection requests from bare-titled “GTM Engineers” are this cohort networking, not a signal about the market for senior work.

Hiring managers have already discounted the title and the credentials behind it. Garrett Wolfe, hiring for his own firm after dozens of interviews: “Clay course graduates have failed basic execution questions,” “some of the worst candidates I’ve interviewed had the most credentials,” and “certifications and Clay bootcamps are largely meaningless”; his senior test is “owns a full GTM motion end-to-end, has a POV on strategy, has receipts” (Garrett Wolfe). HeroHunt’s recruiting guide concedes screening by title is nearly useless because “almost nobody has five years of ‘GTM engineer’ experience” (HeroHunt). Comp is bifurcating rather than compressing: priced postings median $159,500, senior bands $150K–$190K and lead/staff $200K–$250K+, while the junior band is $75K–$95K and agencies bill $2K–$15K a month; Wolfe’s line is that the gap between “a $90K hire who follows a playbook and a $140K hire who builds one is enormous” (Revnu; GTME Pulse survey). The “GTM engineer is dead” narrative does not exist in indexed late-2026 sources; the live critique is that the title is a rebrand of solutions engineering and RevOps and that vendors talk about it more than companies hire for it.

What this means for positioning is narrower than it felt on October 12. The title has acquired an “IC, young, Clay-adjacent” connotation: Clay-sponsored guidance says even “principal-level GTM Engineer” should be an individual contributor, and top-of-market companies label the same function Forward Deployed Engineer, Revenue Strategy, or Director/Head of GTM Engineering instead (The Signal; Revnu). Cannonball GTM publicly rebranded its people from “GTM Engineers” to “Revenue Growth Engineers” because the title “implies you’re only focused on customer acquisition” (Cannonball GTM). So a bare “GTM Engineer” headline with no proof now reads as commodity. But no credible source shows senior practitioners abandoning the words; they keep “GTM engineering” as the category and let outcomes do the differentiating. The flood argues for adding proof around the title, not for deleting it.

The October 12 edit removed the one string recruiters type, from all three fields at once

LinkedIn Recruiter’s Job titles filter matches the title text of Experience entries (Current, or Current-or-past); the Keywords filter is a full-profile text search that includes the headline; and the Seniority filter is inferred by LinkedIn from title and company size, not

self-reported (LinkedIn Recruiter Help; Leonar). Leonar describes title matching as literal ("Product Manager" will not match "PM" or "Product Lead") and says recruiters must add variants themselves; a LinkedIn engineer quoted in 2023 described a title taxonomy with gaps plus a keyword path for the remainder, and neither path is documented to stem "Engineering" to "Engineer" (Leonar; Boolean Strings). A retained-search headhunter who runs Recruiter daily states that headline, experience title and Open to Work titles are three separate fields matched independently, that a headline set "one level up" from the actual title can fail to rank for either, and that "the first word of your headline decides whether our search ever finds you" (Job Search Unlocked). The old configuration had "GTM Engineer" in the headline and in the position title; the new one has the bigram in neither, and if Open to Work titles were changed in the same session, in none of the three.

The query recruiters type is overwhelmingly the bare noun. Of the 251 distinct roles in getaob's 30-day window, **195 (78%) carried no level in the title, 6% Lead/Manager, 4% Senior, 4% Founding, and only 6 (2%) Head/Director**; where a level appears it is a prefix on the same noun ("Senior GTM Engineer", "Lead - GTM Engineer", "Founding GTM Engineer") (getaob). A recruiter filling any of those seats seeds the title filter with "GTM Engineer" and layers Seniority or years-of-experience filters on top; the new strings match the ~2% of Head/Director searches and miss the other 98%. The second, independent loss is seniority inference. "Director GTM Engineering & Revenue Operations" at a company LinkedIn sees as one person, and "Founder & Principal", are the inputs that push the inferred bucket to Director or Owner/Partner, and recruiters filling Senior or Lead IC seats commonly restrict Seniority to Senior and Manager (Leonar). The earlier report also found the same practitioner reporting that "Head of" and "Lead" do not reliably register in seniority filters while Director and VP do, which cuts the other way for the few Director searches but does not rescue the IC pool (Job Search Unlocked).

The alternative explanations do not fit a step-function drop. Seasonality softens recruiter activity 20–25% from October into December in vendor datasets, not to zero, and GTM-engineer postings were still running at ~250 a month in late October (FactoryFix; getaob). The broader contraction is real but function-specific: PredictLeads measured US Sales and RevOps openings down 6.8% in the month to September 5, 2026 with head-of-function roles down 27.1% and Director down 15.2%, while "Director of Revenue Operations" postings rose 47% in the same window (PredictLeads). That hurts the Director/Head strings the new headline leans on and leaves the IC noun untouched. Post-edit "cold start" dips are vendor folklore with no data behind them; the one honest test offered is that if inbound is still at the new floor five to six weeks after an edit, the edit's string is the cause rather than indexing lag (SlateGit). Hiring Assistant and AI-Assisted Search are semantic and would probably bridge "Engineering" to "Engineer", but they are Corporate-tier add-ons, Hiring Assistant 2 only begins rolling out in early November, and Hiring Assistant's "candidate interest" signal reads Open to Work details, so an OTW change moves that ordering too (LinkedIn Hiring Assistant; HeroHunt).

Two things need saying plainly. First, the earlier report in this series recommended "Founder & Principal, GTM Engineering" as the current title and told Brent to remove bare "GTM Engineer" from Open to Work; that advice was wrong on the retrieval mechanics and this report reverses it. Second, the edit changed title, headline and Open to Work in one session, so the collapse cannot be attributed between the three. The repair below restores all three deliberately and the six-week plan holds them still so the next reading is attributable.

A configuration that is found by “GTM Engineer” and read as senior

Nothing in this market has been A/B tested; what follows is derived from the documented mechanics and the practitioner rules above, and every claim about seniority buckets should be verified once by asking a recruiter contact to run the filter. The principle is to keep the exact bigram in all three matched fields and carry seniority and proof in the surrounding words, never by swapping the noun.

Field	String	Why
Current position title (Smoothed)	`Principal GTM Engineer`	Keeps the literal bigram for the Job titles filter; “Principal” and “Lead” are in-market prefixes and should infer Senior/Manager rather than Director/Owner. Add a second concurrent position under the same Smoothed company entry titled `Founder` so the founder fact is on the profile without polluting the matched title. Fallback if two positions is unacceptable: `Principal GTM Engineer & Founder` as one string.
Headline (203 chars)	`Principal GTM Engineer | Production AI agent systems for B2B SaaS GTM teams: evals, approval gates, observability | GTM Systems & Revenue Operations | Founder, Smoothed | ex-Sales Director, 143% to quota`	Bigram inside the first 25 characters and the ~80-character mobile preview; the $200K–$330K strings (“GTM Systems”, “Revenue Operations”) present literally; production proof and the revenue number for the LLM evaluator.
Open to Work (Recruiters only), five slots	`GTM Engineer · Lead GTM Engineer · Director, GTM Systems · Director of Revenue Operations · Head of GTM Engineering`	Bare noun plus step-ups; a slate of step-ups only is the documented failure mode. “Recruiters only” keeps the #OpenToWork frame off the profile buyers see. Full-time and contract; Los Angeles and Remote; all workplace types.
Skills (pinned)	`GTM Engineering · Revenue Operations ·`	Skills is a Boolean-capable Recruiter filter and the

Field	String	Why
	`Artificial Intelligence (AI)`	place where the "Engineering" form bridges the noun.
Skills (unpinned, true)	`Go-to-Market Engineering`, `Clay`, `Apollo`, `HubSpot`, `Salesforce`, `Python`, `SQL`, `LLMOps`	Clay and Apollo are confirmed hands-on as of October 28; Clay appears in 40% of sampled GTM-engineering postings and HubSpot in 37%.
About, first 300 chars	"I am a GTM engineer who designs, governs and operates production AI systems for B2B SaaS GTM teams…" then use "GTM engineering" naturally in later paragraphs	Keywords search hits either form; the evaluator quotes the opening.

The Open to Work slate deserves one more justification. Open to Work is Recruiter's "highest-conversion spotlight", LinkedIn documents that OTW job titles plus location and job type are what make a profile "show up in search results when recruiters look for suitable job candidates", and the same headhunter reports that "most executives load five title slots with step-ups only, and headhunters never see them" (Leonar; LinkedIn Help; Job Search Unlocked). Whether "GTM Engineer" is an accepted typeahead string in the OTW editor in November 2026 cannot be confirmed from the web and has to be checked live; if it is not, "Go-to-Market Engineer" is the next string to try. Answer every InMail, including declines, because LinkedIn switches Open to Work off for members who stop responding, and InMail responsiveness feeds the candidate-interest ordering that Hiring Assistant uses (HeroHunt).

Skip the strings that look senior but match nothing. "AI GTM Engineer" and "Agentic GTM" are vendor categories no top practitioner uses as a title; "Head of GTM Engineering" alone matches about six postings a month; "GTM Systems Architect", the June 2026 title, is the kind of non-standard string that starves Recommended Matches (getaob; LinkedIn Help). Parentheticals such as "(Director-level)" inside the Experience title are of unknown effect on taxonomy matching; keep the position title clean and put qualifiers in the headline.

Senior practitioners sell a method; buyers find them through referrals, not titles

The independents who win clients in 2026 do not lead with "GTM Engineer" and have not abandoned it either; they lead with a named method and keep "GTM engineering" as the category word. Jordan Crawford's Blueprint leads with "The data IS the message" and his own labels (Pain-Qualified Segments, Permissionless Value Props), describes himself as "Clay advisor & investor", and pitches "Most consultants create dependency. I create capability"; Kellen Casebeer's Deal Lab leads with "Find Message-Market-Fit" and rebranded his 1,650-member community from "Clay Cafe" to "GTM Cafe" in December 2025 so it no longer named a tool; Scott Martinis calls himself a "GTM Architect who builds revenue engines"; Jake Bivens argues "a revenue engineer does not

own a single channel or tool. They own the system" (Blueprint; The Deal Lab; GTM Engineer Pulse #2; QC Growth). The one label gaining ground in 2026, "Forward Deployed GTM Engineer/Architect", is used by Clay, Attio, Bitscale and Artisan for in-house seats, not by independents, and there is no evidence consulting buyers use it (Bitscale). Databar's positioning advice for freelancers is the operative rule: a specific service for a specific buyer ("I build outbound infrastructure for Series A SaaS companies"), because "I help companies with their GTM" "sounds fine and sells nothing" (Databar).

Acquisition runs through warm networks first and owned audience second. Hinge's 2026 High Growth Study, as cited, puts referrals and direct human outreach at nearly two-thirds of new professional-services business, and fractional-consulting guides report 92.8% of fractional consultants getting clients through network referrals, with the warning that referrals "run dry after about 18 months" without an outbound channel (GTMbud; Lilach Bullock). Databar's channel ranking is the forwardable ask to one's own network, anonymized problem breakdowns on LinkedIn and in RevOps communities, partnerships with marketing agencies and VC platform teams, and cold outreach to recently funded companies or those posting RevOps and GTM-engineer roles (Databar). Crawford's reach is podcasts (GTM Live, GTMnow, The Transaction), a Pavilion feature and a URL-to-playbook lead magnet; Casebeer's is the community attached to a six-person agency (Pavilion/Topline). A recruiter writing for Pavilion's community describes what makes an outside operator credible to buyers now: "Lead with the problem, not the CV," "AI fluency is now a filtering criterion, and you need a view on it," and trust built "through warm networks… visibility, generosity, and consistent thinking" (Pavilion community). Nowhere in this does a buyer search LinkedIn for "Director GTM Engineering"; the headline change could not have produced consulting clients, and that is the sense in which October 12 was a mistake for the primary goal too.

Pricing stratifies by seniority and scope, and the expert band is well above what the practice has been charging if it sits in the fractional-mid range. GTME's May 2026 guide prices mid-level fractional operators at $100–175/hr (about $8–14K a month at 20 hours a week), senior at $175–250/hr ($14–20K) and **expert, six-plus years, at $250–350/hr ($20–28K a month)**, on a monthly retainer with a three-month minimum and ±20% hour flex, with outcome-based pricing only as a bonus component (GTME). Databar cites the same $250–350 experienced band (Databar). The agency tier is the floor to stay away from: GTM Walnut from $2.5K a month, The GTM Engineering Company $5–7K, The Kiln $10K+ with a three-month minimum, QC Growth $12–15K for systems and ops and $15–20K full service (Valley). The two most credible solo-led shops price their entry products as pilots: Deal Lab's Message-Market-Fit Pilot at $6,500 a month for four months, Blueprint at three-month engagements pitched as "less than a single SDR hire" (The Deal Lab; Blueprint). For a PE reference point, Clay's PE playbook records one portco paying $60K a year for a contractor to research 2,000 accounts plus $50K for Clay (Clay PE playbook).

Proof formats converge on named, LinkedIn-linked testimonials with one before/after number each. Blueprint's page carries name, title, company and LinkedIn link per testimonial, with figures such as contact accuracy 15% to 95% and BDR pipeline $30K to $160K+ a month, plus project cards ("47,228 3PL warehouses scored against 20 signals"); Deal Lab uses one named case (21 pilot signups, three paid deals including a $100K+ ACV) and anonymized sector cases; agencies use logo walls and self-reported aggregate pipeline, which buyers are told to discount by asking for "two clients at your stage" (Blueprint; The Deal Lab; Valley). Deliverables that double as proof are a cleaned CRM, a written runbook and a recorded walkthrough; buyer vetting checklists ask for anonymized examples of systems built for similar companies and for the client, not the

operator, to own tool accounts (Databar; GTME). The differentiator the market names is strategic judgment plus system ownership: Clay's PE playbook says model providers supply reasoning "but not the data pipelines, guardrails, workflow logic, or write-back layers that PE teams need," that "fully autonomous outbound SDRs consistently underperform and damage domain reputation," and that human-reviewed AI drafts are the recommended middle tier (Clay PE playbook). No GTM practitioner was found publishing evals, approval gates, observability or cost engineering as a differentiator, and none publishes "what broke" postmortems; that territory is unoccupied, but buyers are not yet asking for it in those words, so it has to be translated into theirs: runs without me, nothing sends without a human click, defensible in a board meeting, repeatable across a portfolio.

Adjacent senior seats: GTM Systems and Director of RevOps carry the money and are claimable

The senior seats above the IC pool are real but thin, and they sort cleanly into two gates: ops-leadership seats that screen on RevOps tenure and systems depth with no coding interview, and engineering-management seats that require professional software engineering. The table reflects verified late-2026 postings.

Category	Exact strings seen	Posted base	Gate	Claimable for Brent?
GTM Systems leadership	Senior Director of GTM Systems (LaunchDarkly); Director, GTM Systems (Checkr); Head of GTM Systems & AI (360Learning); Head of GTM Systems (Anthropic)	$204K–$331K; $240K–$282K; $150K–$210K	10–15+ yrs Sales/RevOps leadership, Salesforce/CPQ depth, team-building; no coding	Yes at AI-native Series B–D that word it as "GTM Systems & AI"; screened out at $1B+ Salesforce/SOX shops on systems tenure, not on code
AI-enablement RevOps	Director of GTM Data, Processes, and AI Enablement (MaintainX); Director of GTM & AI Enablement (Causal); AI GTM Operations Lead (Overview)	not disclosed	10+ yrs revenue ops, hands-on AI in sales tooling, 3+ yrs people leadership	Yes; the hands-on AI requirement is the differentiator
Director of Revenue Operations	Director of Revenue Operations (+47% postings	leadership-tier median $175K advertised;	RevOps leadership; AI-fluent premium rising	Yes at AI-native companies; the leadership

Category	Exact strings seen	Posted base	Gate	Claimable for Brent?
	Aug to Sep 2026); Head of Revenue Operations	guide bands $210K–$300K		record is a seven-person team in 2010–2015 and two SDRs, so lead with systems ownership
Director GTM Engineering (player-coach)	Director, GTM Engineering (Deepgram); Sr. Manager, GTM Engineering (6sense); Head of GTM Engineering & Systems (Fireworks)	$200K–$275K; $150K–$181K	Deepgram: "write, review, debug, and maintain production-quality code" independent of AI tools	Borderline; only where the JD says "shipped production systems/agents" rather than "professional software engineer"
Revenue Engineering / GTM AI Engineering	Director, Revenue Engineering (Nooks); Head of GTM AI and Engineering (Samsara)	$260K–$300K; $196K–$350K	manages engineers; 12+ yrs SWE/data science/revenue tech; 5+ yrs managing managers	No
Forward Deployed Engineer	~1,276 live FDE postings; GTM variants at Attio ($150K–$200K OTE), G2 ($125K–$135K)	median posted base $203K; frontier labs $243K	Python/LLM stack, SWE loop; GTM variants are post-sale SE work	Lab FDE no; FDE-GTM at startups reachable but priced like a senior SE

Sources: LaunchDarkly, Checkr, 360Learning and Anthropic postings (WTTJ; bebee Checkr; JobLeads; General Catalyst board); MaintainX and Causal (usaremotejobs; Accel board); RevOps bands (PredictLeads; RevGuild; Recruits Lab); Deepgram, 6sense, Fireworks (Built In Austin; GTM Engineer Pulse #47; Landbase); Nooks and Samsara (Rise; The Muse); FDE (Plank; Attio).

Three patterns matter. "Head of GTM Engineering" is credible as a positioning title but not as a search-volume title: getaob counted six Head/Director roles in 30 days, Landbase found 85 of 89 companies posting exactly one IC "GTM Engineer" and nothing above it, and the only team-building Head title in that pool was Fireworks after a $1.5B Series D (getaob; Landbase). The strings that employers used for the larger, better-paid seats in H2 2026 are compounds of "GTM" with "Systems" or "AI": Checkr's "Head of AI-Driven GTM Systems & Architecture", 360Learning's "Head of GTM Systems & AI", Fireworks' "Head of GTM Engineering & Systems", MaintainX's "Director of GTM Data, Processes, and AI Enablement"; Deepgram's JD treats "GTM Engineering, RevOps, Sales Ops, or business systems" as interchangeable function names and Anthropic's treats "GTM systems, RevOps, or business systems" the same way (Built In Austin; General Catalyst board). Betts names "RevOps AI Integrator" and "GTM

Automation Lead" as emerging titles whose comp has not settled, and reports AI-fluent candidates commanding an unquantified premium on otherwise flat 2026 RevOps bands (Betts). And the engineering gate is explicit where it exists: Deepgram wants someone who can write and debug production code without AI tools; Samsara wants five years managing engineering managers. The honest line from the background file, "designs, governs and operates" production systems with code written under CI-enforced contracts and tests, is a differentiator for GTM Systems, AI-enablement and Director-of-RevOps seats and should never be stretched to the Nooks or Samsara seats.

Six weeks: restore the strings, launch the method, measure both goals separately

Week 0 is a baseline, taken before anything changes. Record the live headline, position title, Open to Work titles and visibility, pinned skills, and the weekly "search appearances" count with the keywords LinkedIn lists under it; count recruiter InMails and consulting discovery calls for the prior four weeks from the inbox; note getaob's 30-day distinct-role count (251 on October 26) as the market control. Check two things the earlier audit flagged that could have moved in the same session: whether Open to Work is still on (LinkedIn removes it when InMails go unanswered) and whether its visibility was changed from All members to Recruiters only, which alone removes founder and Sales Navigator visibility of the signal (LinkedIn Help).

Week 1 makes every LinkedIn edit in the table in one sitting, then stops. Position title to "Principal GTM Engineer" with "Founder" as a second concurrent position at Smoothed; the 203-character headline; the five Open to Work titles, Recruiters only, both employment types, Los Angeles and Remote; pinned skills; About opening in the first person with "GTM engineer" in the first sentence and "GTM engineering" later; the Smoothed bullets from the earlier report, anonymized per the background file (a multi-product B2B asset-management SaaS marketing team; a PE-backed CX-assurance SaaS). Fix the Crealytics title to VP of Sales so the uploaded resume and the profile agree, since the evaluator quotes inconsistencies verbatim. Then hold the strings untouched through week 6; the only data on edit cold-start says repeated edits restart the cycle and that five to six weeks at the floor is the point where the string, not the indexing, is proven to be the cause (SlateGit). Ask one recruiter contact with a Recruiter seat to run `"GTM Engineer"` on Current title and the Seniority filter against the profile once in week 2; that single check settles the taxonomy and seniority-bucket questions no public source can.

Weeks 1 through 6 run client acquisition on its own track, because nothing on LinkedIn's structured fields reaches a buyer. Name the method once and use it everywhere: the background file's own language ("calibrate before you automate", "failure is a designed state", nothing sends without a human click) is already a method vocabulary and the market shows named methods travel through referrals in a way "GTM engineering services" does not. State the buyer in one line, the Databar way: production AI agent systems for Series A–C and PE-backed B2B SaaS GTM teams, built in the client's accounts and handed over. Publish two anonymized case studies with one before/after number each and an H2 titled "What happens when a step fails" (the content pipeline: 11 steps and 16 days to five stages, eval catch 100% / fix 86% / unjustified fixes 0%; the knowledge library: 21,000 documents, $0.008 per answered question), because named-and-numbered proof is what the credible solo operators use and the offshore tier cannot fake. Ask the two current clients for a LinkedIn-linked testimonial with one number, once the pending disclosure agreement allows it. Make the forwardable ask to the warm network in week 1, and build a 20–30 account list of recently funded Series A–C and PE-

backed B2B SaaS companies that are posting RevOps or GTM-engineer roles, since a posted seat is a budget line the practice can fill at $20–28K a month against a fully loaded hire above $280K (Yalc). Price the entry product as a three-to-four-month pilot at the expert band with a 20% results component at most, client-owned tool accounts, and a runbook plus recorded walkthrough as the handover artifact. For PE, the entry point is a single portco CRO or an operating partner's bench, and the pitch is Clay's own vocabulary back to them: guardrails, workflow logic, write-back layers, human-reviewed drafts, portfolio-repeatable (Clay PE playbook).

Measure in two columns. Recruiter track: weekly search appearances and whether "GTM Engineer" appears in the listed keywords (it should by week 2 if the edit took); recruiter InMails per week against the pre-October-12 rate; the seniority bucket reported by the recruiter contact. The decision rule at week 6: if InMails are back to at least half the pre-edit rate with getaob's count flat, the strings worked and the remaining gap is the structural "fewer but better" effect of agentic sourcing; if they are still at the floor with postings flat, test the single-string fallback title for the next six weeks and nothing else. Client track: discovery calls booked per week, source of each (referral, content, outbound, Clay-adjacent community), proposals sent at the expert band, and one signed pilot by week 6 as the target. Connection requests from bare-titled "GTM Engineers" are noise and should not be counted as anything; accept the ones with a running system and ignore the rest.

Conclusion

The flood and the collapse are two unrelated facts that arrived at the same time, and treating them as one problem produced the wrong edit. The flood is a quality flood at the entry tier that makes the bare title worthless as proof; the collapse is a retrieval failure caused by deleting a literal string from three independently matched fields. The repair is not a retreat to the old headline but a split: the structured fields speak LinkedIn's language (the bare noun, step-up titles, standard skills) while the free text speaks the buyer's (a running system, a human click before anything sends, a cost per unit, a named method). The two audiences never read the same field first, which is why one string change cannot serve both and why the strategic goal was never going to move from a headline.

The more durable implication is that the title is becoming a category word the way "consultant" did, and the senior market has already moved to compound strings ("GTM Systems & AI", "Director of Revenue Operations", "GTM Data, Processes and AI Enablement") that describe scope rather than craft. A practice that can show evals, approval gates, observability and cost engineering in production holds vocabulary that no GTM competitor is yet publishing and no buyer is yet requesting; the six-week window is the time to introduce that vocabulary in buyers' terms while the structured fields quietly go back to matching the queries recruiters actually type.